



Plants and people

The earliest people were hunter-gatherers, always on the move searching for food such as meat, berries, and seeds. Then around 12,000 years ago, the first farming began in the Fertile Crescent, a region in the Middle East. Here, people settled down and learned to sow, harvest, and store crops—the ancestors of wild grasses—and domesticate animals.

How plants have changed

Humans have cultivated many plants since farming began. Teosinte, an ancient wild relative of corn, bore just a few hard kernels. Farmers noticed that some teosinte plants produced more kernels and with a softer texture so planted these the next season. Over time, this selective farming method led to the large cobs we eat today.

A hard coat makes the few kernels tough to eat.



Teosinte



Corn

Sowing seeds > For thousands of years, people have sowed seeds by hand. Here, as the man drives the plow, the woman follows behind sowing the seeds.

